

Trail proposal would link Heritage and Armstrong

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A local organization is looking to connect two existing trails along the Allegheny River by creating a link that snakes through 17 river towns.

Friends of the Riverfront, which developed and maintains the 21-mile Three Rivers Heritage Trail that runs along the banks of Pittsburgh's rivers, is seeking proposals from companies interested in developing a feasibility study that will outline how to connect it to the Armstrong Trail.

"The number of people who use the Three Rivers Heritage Trail has exceeded our expectations, so it is an exciting step forward for us to begin the process of extending it up river where it will eventually link with the Armstrong Trail," said Thomas Baxter, executive director of Friends of the Riverfront.

The Allegheny Valley Land Trust has converted more than 30 miles of abandoned railroad lines to create the Armstrong Trail, which begins in Gilpin, Armstrong County, and runs to East Brady, Clarion County.

Some of the Armstrong Trail's development, however, has been stalled for a number of years by legal disputes over who owns the abandoned rail lines.

The new 34-mile trail would run along the Allegheny River starting in Millvale.

Squirrel Hill residents Mary Shaw, and her husband, Roy Weil, who are avid bicyclists, welcome the link to the Armstrong Trail.

"It's a fantastic idea," Shaw said. "The section of the trail in Freeport is important because it is a junction for other trails that have been completed or being developed."

Some of the biggest challenges will be obtaining the rights of way from businesses, including railroads, that own riverfront property, Baxter said.

"We try to stress that providing an easement through their properties is a benefit to the company in terms of employee health and wellness and being good neighbors in the communities where they are located," he said.

In instances where the trail cannot run along the river, cutbacks are developed into local communities.

"These community connections allow us to work around obstacles, but more importantly, they benefit the towns involved by bringing people into the business districts and creating access points to get on the trail," Baxter said.

"It's also important for the people who use the trails to have access to restaurants and other amenities."